Fair Queueing Is Not Enough at Flow Start:
Game-Grade Latency on a Marginal VDSL2 Line with a One-Armed CAKE Router

Emmet
https://github.com/Emmet-v15/one-armed-cake

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Abstract

We report a measurement study of latency under load on a residential VDSL2 line with roughly 5.9 Mbit/s down and 2 Mbit/s up, where the ISP router cannot be modified. A Raspberry Pi 4B attached to one LAN port acts as a *one-armed* router and shapes both directions with CAKE. We make four observations. (i) Shaping both directions on *egress*, after NAT, is what makes per-host fairness possible on such a box, and CAKE's `nat` option is required on the upload side. (ii) Fair queueing does not protect a sparse, game-like flow while many bulk flows are *starting*: with 16 simultaneous uploads, a 50 Hz UDP probe saw worst-case round trips of 97–132 ms and lost 13% of its packets in the first 1.5 s, even though CAKE was the only queue involved. Classifying small UDP packets into CAKE's Voice tin removed the effect entirely (22–40 ms, no loss). (iii) Capping download at 4.5 Mbit/s keeps steady-state latency at a median of 18 ms and a p99 of 26 ms, compared with 165 ms and 229 ms unshaped, but it cannot stop a ∼120 ms p99 transient when a download starts. This is a basic limit of shaping at the receiving end. (iv) Several common measurement methods were misleading on this line: ICMP is policed upstream, TCP-handshake probes turn a single loss into a 1 s sample, and one load generator was throttled on the client host. All code, configuration, and raw data are released.

1 Introduction

Bufferbloat, excessive queueing delay in oversized network buffers, remains the dominant cause of latency spikes on residential links [1]. Modern active queue management (AQM) such as CoDel [2, 3], FQ-CoDel [4], and CAKE [5] solves it when it runs at the bottleneck. The ISP-supplied router usually sits at the bottleneck, and it usually cannot run custom AQM.

This paper documents what it takes to get *game-grade* latency (a steady round trip well under 50 ms while other devices saturate the line) on such a line, using a single-board computer that sits beside the ISP router rather than in front of it. The line is marginal: VDSL2 at ∼88 dB downstream attenuation, SNR margins of 6.6/5.4 dB, and a delivered capacity that drifted between 2.3 and 5.9 Mbit/s over the study.

Contributions.

- A **one-armed shaper design** that shapes both directions on egress, after NAT, so that CAKE's per-host isolation works in both directions. We show why the ingress hook cannot do this and why CAKE's `nat` keyword is required on the upload side (§3).
- A **measurement method** for such a box: a game-style UDP probe to a reflector we control, plus packet-level localization using the fact that each packet crosses the router's single interface four times (§4).
- **Flow-startup vulnerability of fair queueing**: we quantify it and show that a simple size-based classifier eliminates it (§5.1).
- A **download cap sweep** that separates steady-state control, which works, from the flow-start transient, which receiver-side shaping cannot remove (§5.2).
- **Negative results and pitfalls**: priority by demotion, ICMP-driven autorate, and probe and load-generator artifacts (§5.3, §5.4).

2 Background

CoDel [2, 3] drops or marks packets when their queueing delay (*sojourn time*) has exceeded a *target* for at least an *interval*. FQ-CoDel [4] hashes packets into per-flow queues with a CoDel instance each, and serves flows by deficit round robin. Flows that have just become active are kept on a separate "new flows" list, which is served first. This *sparse-flow optimization* is what normally gives low-rate interactive traffic its low latency.

CAKE [5] builds on this with a deficit-mode shaper, per-host fairness (`dual-srchost`/`dual-dsthost`), DiffServ *tins* (in `diffserv4`: Bulk, Best Effort, Video, Voice; Voice is prioritized up to a 25% bandwidth threshold), an `ingress` mode for shaping at the receiving side, an ACK filter, and link-layer overhead compensation.

Shaping download on the *receiving* side is inherently indirect: the real bottleneck buffer is upstream, at the DSLAM. The shaper can only keep that buffer empty

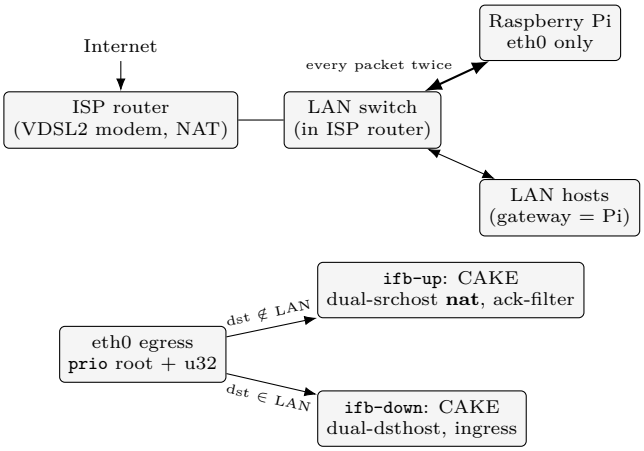


Figure 1: Top: one-armed topology. The Pi serves DHCP and names itself as the gateway, so all traffic hairpins through its single port. Bottom: both directions are classified on eth0 egress and redirected to per-direction CAKE instances. LAN-to-LAN traffic bypasses shaping.

by delivering slightly less than line rate and dropping packets, which signals senders one round trip later. cake-autorate [11] adjusts the shaper rate continuously from ICMP round-trip measurements.

3 System Design

Topology. The Pi (static 192.168.1.2) runs dnsmasq and hands out itself as the default gateway; the ISP router's own DHCP server is disabled (Fig. 1). The Pi masquerades to the ISP router, which NATs again to the Internet. Every forwarded byte crosses the Pi's 1 GbE link twice, which is negligible at these rates.

Why egress, both directions. A tc ingress hook sees inbound packets before conntrack reverses NAT, so every download packet is still addressed to the router itself. Per-host fairness is impossible there. On egress towards the LAN, the destination is the real host. On egress towards the ISP router, however, the source has *already* been masqueraded: counting in a postrouting chain at priority 200 showed 7,600 packets from the router's address and none from the real host. CAKE's `nat` option, which recovers the pre-NAT address from conntrack, is therefore load-bearing on the upload side: without it, `dual-srchost` sees one host and isolates nothing. Download needs no `nat`. A `prio` root with three u32 filters sends LAN→LAN traffic unshaped, traffic to a LAN destination to `ifb-down`, and everything else to `ifb-up`.

Profiles. *Gaming* caps download at 4.5 Mbit/s with CAKE `rtt 30ms`. *Max* leaves download `unlimited`; CAKE still provides flow isolation and statistics. Upload is capped at 1.8 Mbit/s in both (sync 2.0 Mbit/s), with PTM overhead compensation (`overhead 34 mpu 68 ptm`) and the ACK filter. Profiles switch at run time with `tc qdisc change`, which keeps queued packets and counters.

Game-packet classifier. An nftables rule in the `forward` hook, where real hosts are visible in both directions, sets DSCP EF on

- LAN-originated UDP packets of ≤300 bytes, and
- LAN-bound UDP packets of ≤1000 bytes not from port 443.

EF maps to CAKE's Voice tin. The port-443 exclusion keeps QUIC data out, and the Voice tin's 25% threshold bounds any misclassification. Upload uses `wash` so the mark is not leaked upstream.

Monitoring. A Bun dashboard reads per-direction byte counters from sysfs at 20 Hz and per-host counters from nftables dynamic sets at 1 Hz. It measures latency with the same 10 Hz game-style UDP echo used in §4, marked EF.

4 Methodology

Testbed. Raspberry Pi 4B, Debian 13, Linux 6.18, `sch_cake`. The client is a Windows 11 PC on wired 1 GbE. The reflector is a cloud VM with a median idle round trip of 15.9 ms from the client.

Probe. Each trial sends a UDP datagram with a 64-byte payload (92-byte IP packet) every 20 ms, carrying an 8-digit sequence number. The reflector echoes datagrams of ≤128 bytes. A probe with no echo by the end of the trial counts as lost. This resembles a game's input stream in size and rate, unlike ICMP (policed on this path, §5.4) or TCP handshakes.

Trials. Each trial is 2 s idle, then 8 s of load, then 2 s idle. We report the *start* window (the first 1.5 s of load) and the *steady* window (the rest of the load) separately. Upload load is N TCP streams to a sink on the reflector. Download load is 4 curl processes fetching a public 100 MB file. Conditions are interleaved within each repetition (5 repetitions for upload, 3 for download, 38 trials in total), so capacity drift affects all conditions alike. Tables report, per condition, the median across repetitions with the min–max range in parentheses.

Localization. On a one-armed router a packet crosses eth0 four times: from the client (A), towards the ISP router after the upload qdisc (B), the reply from the ISP router (C), and towards the client after the download qdisc (D). A single `tcpdump` on eth0, matching packets by payload sequence number and direction by MAC address, separates time in the upload qdisc ($B - A$),

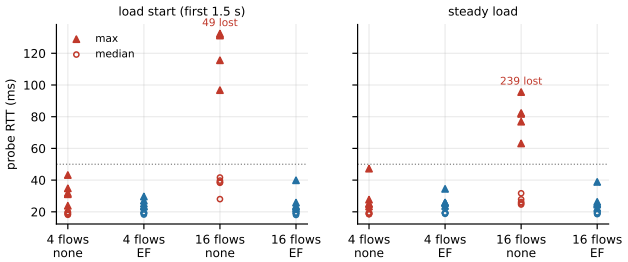


Figure 2: Per-trial median (○) and maximum (△) probe round trip. Red: no classifier; blue: small UDP in the Voice tin. Dotted line: 50 ms.

everything beyond the router ($C - B$), and time in the download qdisc ($D - C$), and pinpoints where each lost packet disappeared.

5 Results

5.1 Upload: fair queueing at flow start

With 4 uploads, fair queueing alone works: the start-window maximum is 24–43 ms and there is no loss (Table 1). With 16 uploads it does not: the median probe round trip doubles to 39 ms, the worst case reaches 97–132 ms, and 49 of 375 probes (13%) are lost in the first 1.5 s. The effect persists into steady state (p99 61–87 ms, 239/1625 lost). With the classifier on, the 16-flow case is indistinguishable from the 4-flow case: maximum 22–40 ms and no loss in any trial (Fig. 2).

Where the delay and loss occur. Packet capture (Table 2) places all of it inside CAKE's upload qdisc on the Pi. The ISP router, line, and Internet path stayed flat at 15.6 ms, and every lost probe disappeared between A and B. Lowering the upload cap to 1.6 or 1.4 Mbit/s did not help, which rules out a hidden queue in the ISP router.

Mechanism. We did not instrument the scheduler directly, but the data are consistent with the following explanation. When 16 flows start together, each one is "new" in the DRR sense, so the probe no longer has the new-flow list to itself and waits its turn behind up to 16 quanta. At 1.8 Mbit/s one 1514-byte quantum takes 6.7 ms, which bounds the wait at $16 \times 6.7 \approx 108$ ms, above the observed in-qdisc maximum of 75 ms. Meanwhile CAKE's aggregate backlog peaked at ∼1.15 s of data. Probe packets that wait longer than CoDel's target for longer than an interval make the probe's own CoDel instance drop them, which would explain losses that occur only inside the qdisc. EF classification moves the probe into the Voice tin, which is served before Best Effort, and the effect disappears.

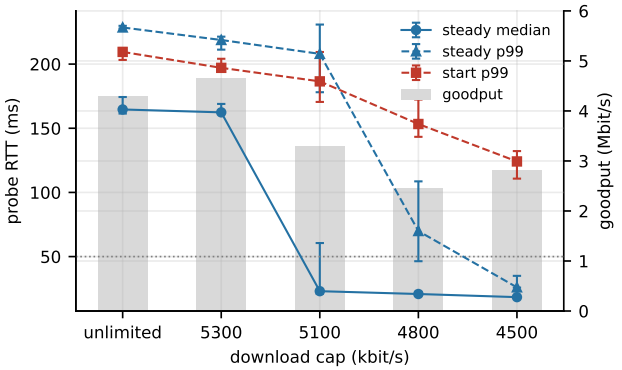


Figure 3: Download cap sweep (classifier on). Lines: steady median, steady p99 and start p99 (bars: min–max over repetitions). Grey bars: goodput.

5.2 Download: steady state versus flow start

Unshaped, the DSLAM buffer fills and the probe sees a median of 165 ms, a p99 of 229 ms, and 7% loss in steady state (Table 3, Fig. 3). An independent web-based test agreed: +173 ms under download, +7 ms under upload. A 5.3 Mbit/s cap was above that day's capacity and behaved like no cap. 5.1 Mbit/s was at the knee and bimodal. At 4.8 Mbit/s and below, CAKE owns the queue: at 4.5 Mbit/s the steady median is 18 ms and the p99 26 ms, with no loss.

The start window tells a different story. Even at 4.5 Mbit/s, the p99 over the first 1.5 s is 111–132 ms, *with or without* the classifier. We attribute this to the receiving-side limit described in the background: a new download's slow-start burst arrives at the DSLAM faster than line rate and queues there before any packet reaches the Pi. (We did not capture this directly; the insensitivity to marking is what points upstream.) The Pi can only slow the sender one round trip later, and DSCP marks cannot help a queue that sits upstream. The classifier still helps in steady state (p99 26 vs. 50 ms at 4.5 Mbit/s).

The cost is throughput: 2.8 Mbit/s at the 4.5 Mbit/s cap against 4.3 Mbit/s unshaped over 8 s windows. In earlier 20 s runs with a TCP probe, the same cap delivered 3.1–3.3 Mbit/s. A shorter CAKE interval (`rtt 30ms` instead of 100 ms) reduced the steady-state maximum from ∼50 to ∼45 ms at equal throughput in those runs.

5.3 Pilot observations

The following were measured earlier with a TCP-handshake probe and fewer repetitions. We report them as observations, not controlled results.

- **Priority by demotion hurts everyone.** Marking all traffic except one host CS1 (Bulk tin) gave that

		load start (first 1.5 s)			steady load		
flows	marking	median	max	lost	median	p99	lost
4	none	19 (18–20)	32 (24–43)	0/375	19 (18–19)	23 (22–35)	0/1625
4	EF	19 (18–20)	25 (23–30)	0/375	19 (19–19)	23 (23–29)	0/1625
16	none	39 (28–42)	131 (97–132)	49/375	26 (25–32)	67 (61–87)	239/1625
16	EF	19 (18–20)	24 (22–40)	0/375	19 (19–20)	23 (22–33)	0/1625

Table 1: Game-style probe round trip (ms) while N TCP uploads start simultaneously; upload capped at 1.8 Mbit/s. "EF" = small-UDP classifier on. Lost = probes lost / probes sent, summed over 5 repetitions.

	upload qdisc		beyond router	
16 uploads	max	lost	median	max
unmarked, start	75.4	8	15.7	17.0
unmarked, steady	51.8	11	15.6	23.2
EF, start	6.6	0	15.7	17.3
EF, steady	7.4	0	15.6	24.4

Table 2: Packet-level localization (ms; one trial per condition). No probe was lost beyond the router or in the download qdisc.

host 20–91 ms loaded median (peaks 96–178 ms). Per-host fairness gave 16–17 ms (peaks 20–21 ms) at equal goodput. Bulk's long AQM target (161 ms up, 68 ms down at these rates) lets demoted traffic build a queue in the shared bottleneck.

- **ICMP-driven autorate failed on an ICMP-policed path.** cake-autorate logged 7,202 "reflector misbehaving" events and zero bufferbloat detections in 24 h, and held delivered throughput at 3.78 Mbit/s against 4.91 (static 5.3 Mbit/s cap) and 5.06–5.15 (unshaped). It never received a usable signal, so it steered blind.
- **The ACK filter** reduced peak loaded latency on this asymmetric line from ∼1200 ms to ∼130 ms in a single comparison.

5.4 Measurement pitfalls

- **ICMP is policed.** To the same anycast address at the same time, under load, ICMP echo lost 38% (25/40) while TCP handshakes succeeded 40/40. Ping-derived loss and ping-driven controllers are invalid on this path.
- **TCP-handshake probes turn loss into latency.** A lost SYN is retransmitted after the kernel's 1 s initial timeout, so one lost packet appears as a ∼1020 ms sample. Handshakes to an anycast service also scattered between 16 and 40 ms at idle, against a p95 of 16.9 ms for the UDP echo.
- **The load generator itself.** On the client, sockets owned by one interpreter received at ∼0.45 Mbit/s while curl and another runtime reached 4.6–4.7 Mbit/s on the same URL, back to back. Experiments using that generator showed multi-second latencies that looked like severe bufferbloat. We found this only by cross-checking with an independent client, and switched to curl for download load. We could not identify the cause.

6 Discussion

Why not rely on applications to mark DSCP? Most games do not, and Windows clears DSCP by default unless a QoS policy is configured. Classifying at the router by packet size is crude but effective. Game input and voice packets are small, while bulk transfers are dominated by full-size packets and TCP, which the rules exclude. The worst case of a false positive is bounded by the Voice tin's threshold. Marking LAN-bound packets EF has a side benefit on Wi-Fi, where EF commonly maps to the voice access category [8].

The flow-start problem is general. Any fair-queueing scheduler that relies on sparse-flow priority is exposed when the number of simultaneously starting flows times the per-quantum transmission time approaches the latency budget. At 1.8 Mbit/s and a 50 ms budget that is about 7 flows, which cloud-sync and game-update clients routinely exceed. At 100 Mbit/s the same budget allows over 400. The problem is therefore specific to low-rate uplinks, which is exactly where bufferbloat mitigation is most needed.

The download transient needs help from outside. Removing the start-of-download spike requires the queue to be managed at the bottleneck itself (ISP-side AQM, or L4S [9]) or senders that do not overshoot, such as paced congestion control like BBR [10]. A receiving-side shaper can only bound how long the transient lasts.

Recommendations. (1) Shape both directions on egress, and on the upload side use `nat`. (2) Prefer per-host fairness over priority by demotion. (3) On uplinks of a few Mbit/s, prioritize small UDP packets into a bounded priority tin. (4) Choose the download cap from a sweep of the tail (p99), not the median, and leave a margin for capacity drift. (5) Measure with a UDP

			load start		steady load			
cap (kbit/s)	rtt	mark	median	p99	median	p99	lost	goodput
unlimited	100	EF	149 (137–161)	209 (203–213)	165 (161–174)	229 (228–230)	70/975	4.28 (4.27–4.29)
5300	30	EF	154 (133–155)	197 (196–204)	162 (162–169)	219 (211–221)	49/975	4.65 (4.63–4.68)
5100	30	EF	129 (127–140)	187 (171–209)	23 (21–61)	208 (178–231)	14/975	3.28 (3.04–3.47)
4800	30	EF	25 (25–25)	153 (143–172)	21 (20–22)	70 (46–109)	0/975	2.46 (2.06–3.05)
4500	30	EF	22 (22–23)	124 (111–132)	18 (18–19)	26 (26–35)	0/975	2.80 (2.78–3.02)
4500	30	none	22 (22–55)	130 (129–137)	20 (20–20)	50 (49–98)	0/975	2.66 (2.40–2.69)

Table 3: Probe round trip (ms) under 4-stream download, by download cap (wire rate) and CAKE `rtt`. Goodput is averaged over the whole 8 s load period, including slow start, so it understates steady-state rate.

echo to a reflector you control, and validate the load generator against an independent client.

7 Limitations

This is one line, one client, one reflector and one day, with 8 s trials and 3–5 repetitions per condition. The load is synthetic bulk TCP rather than real applications, and the probe imitates game traffic rather than being a game. No wireless clients were tested. Download goodput includes slow start. Line capacity drifted during the study, and conditions near the knee (5.1 Mbit/s) were bimodal. The localization data (Table 2) comes from one trial per condition. The pilot observations used a noisier probe.

8 Related Work

Gettys and Nichols [1] brought bufferbloat to wide attention. CoDel [2, 3] and FQ-CoDel [4] are the standard AQM and scheduler responses; RFC 7567 [6] recommends deploying AQM widely. CAKE [5] integrates shaping, host isolation, and DiffServ for home gateways, and its authors discuss ingress shaping's limits. cake-autorate [11] targets variable-rate links using ICMP one-way delays. EF is defined in RFC 3246 [7]. We add measurements of CAKE on a marginal DSL line from a one-armed deployment, and isolate the flow-start weakness at low rates.

9 Availability

Shaper, dashboard, reflector, experiment driver, analysis scripts, and raw per-trial data: `https://github.com/Emmet-v15/one-armed-cake`. Every number in Tables 1–3 is regenerated from the raw data by `tools/analyze.py`.

Acknowledgment. Implementation was AI-assisted. All measurements were taken on the testbed described.

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